

production as much as it makes sense—electronics, speakers, connectivity modules, controllers, displays. The goal is a verticalised value chain in India, not just a delivery outpost.

Q: With 5,000 people in India, do you partner with Indian IT services companies?

A: We do the core work ourselves. But we partner where it makes sense. The Wipro example is relevant here. Following the DTS divestiture, we continue to collaborate with them, and that's probably our most significant external partnership right now.

No one in this industry can do everything alone. Companies that tried to keep everything in-house have struggled or had to pivot. The automotive industry is becoming more like tech—a network of value contributors rather than a linear supply chain.

The question is: what do you bring to that network that others genuinely need? For us, that's user experience expertise, integration capability, speed, and ability to productise at automotive grade. Those are the things we protect and develop. Around those, we build the right partnerships.

Q: Samsung acquired HARMAN in 2017. How has that relationship played out for both sides?

A: It's been productive. On the product side, one concrete example is display technology. Our joint work with Samsung has produced a QLED equivalent—the same optical quality as OLED but around 30% cheaper. That's a real commercial breakthrough for in-car displays. Another area is ReadyCare, our driver monitoring product, which we're developing with Samsung Health.

Q: AI is reshaping every industry. How are you embedding it?

A: We have a clear, two-part view on this. The first is enterprise AI—using it to reimagine our internal end-to-end processes. We've taken a focused approach: identify the highest-value processes, reimagine them with agentic AI, and generate real productivity gains before moving to the next one.

Writing test cases, which used to be three per engineering day, has been multiplied tenfold. We've benchmarked this across 40 to 50 companies, and our conclusion is: start narrow, go deep, deliver results, then expand.

We've also built in a cultural dimension. Each senior leadership team member has an AI buddy, a younger talent from the organisation who reverse-mentors us on using AI effectively.

The second front is AI in the product itself. In a car, this means an AI-orchestrated experience that draws from multiple context layers simultaneously and adapts the in-cabin experience in real time.

Q: With AI driving significant productivity improvements in software development, do you see a reduced need for outsourcing partners?

A: Our view is actually the opposite of contraction. We believe we can nearly double the size of the company in the next five years—both in lifestyle and automotive. The challenge isn't managing decline; it's managing growth. Are there still unknowns? Of course. Some AI promises are yet to be fully delivered. But this is the direction we're heading.

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Q: The past 12 to 18 months have brought significant geopolitical turbulence. How does the company navigate this?

A: The first thing I've learned is that life is a training centre. What matters most is mental resilience—not just your own, but of the entire organisation.

On the practical side, there are real compliance requirements. Supply chain pressures and tariff situations add further complexity. These are real challenges.

But the formula is: rigorous scenario-based risk management combined with the cultural capability to adapt quickly when the unexpected happens.

Q: With Sound United's portfolio added to the existing brands—JBL, Harman Kardon, Mark Levinson, Bowers & Wilkins—you now manage a very large number of brands. Is consolidation on the agenda?

A: We manage brand portfolios actively, just as we manage business portfolios. Each serves a distinct audience and positioning. There's no pressing strategic need for consolidation, and nothing dramatic is planned. **BT**